44

Kartar Singh Sarabha

Did Bhagat Singh set out to die from the very beginning? Was this how he planned to sacrifice himself in the cause of India's freedom? Or was he just oblivious to death? If so, could he have saved himself if he so wished? Of course, in one sense we will never know what he thought or might have intended. In another sense, however, there is the evidence. How is this evidence to be interpreted? Martyrdom was, of course, something of which Bhagat Singh had early knowledge. To be a 'martyr' was to be called a 'shaheed'. There was no nobler way to fight for India's Independence than to die in its cause. And Bhagat Singh was not the first to do so. It was the ultimate sacrifice that a freedom fighter could make for the love of his motherland, and India had an illustrious line of shaheeds'. Two incidents in particular left a lasting impression on his young mind. The first such event was when Bhagat Singh was still only a child of eight years of age. This was the hanging of seven Ghadar martyrs over 16 and 17 November 1915 by the British, in what became known as the First Lahore Conspiracy Case. Among those who were put to death was a man that Bhagat Singh grew up to adore and eventually emulate, by the name Kartar Singh Sarabha, who was barely twenty years old. Such was the devotion that the manner of his death commanded that when in March 1926 Bhagat Singh, Sukhdev and Bhagwati Charan Vohra established the Naujawan Bharat Sabha in Lahore, they consciously set its tone from the outset by unveiling at its inaugural session a portrait of Kartar Singh Sarabha, in what would have been an act of extreme provocation for the authorities as well as an act of sedition. Bhagat Singh himself was known to regularly carry a photograph of Kartar Singh Sarabha in his pocket and was found carrying it when arrested in